

The many ways to brew a cup of coffee

The two most popular styles emerged in Europe at the same time

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Coffee is one of the world's most popular drinks, but not everyone drinks it the same way. The two most popular styles, espresso and filter coffee, were invented in Europe. Turkish coffee is most similar to how people drank coffee centuries ago. And Cuba and Vietnam have their own unique styles.

Transcript

Five ways to brew a cup of coffee

Over 2 billion cups of coffee are consumed around the world every day. But a “cup of coffee” does not mean the same thing everywhere you go.

In this story, we'll take a world tour of the different ways to produce the world's [second-most-popular](#) hot beverage.

We'll start in Europe. Many years ago, Europeans made coffee slowly at home. They boiled water, poured it over coffee grounds, waited for the grounds to settle to the bottom, and sipped carefully. It was

a slow, messy process. People didn't like the gritty taste of grounds in the bottom of their cups, and it took a long time to make.

That was, until 1884, when an Italian hotel owner in Turin invented a machine that would make coffee fast for guests—and best of all the grounds wouldn't settle in the bottom of a customer's cup. The machine forced hot water under pressure through finely-ground coffee. It produced a concentrated shot of coffee in less than a minute.

It was so fast, he called the style “espresso.”

The espresso machine solved two problems **at once**. First, speed—a café could serve dozens of customers an hour **instead of** making them wait. But second, and maybe more important, it made better coffee. The pressure forced hot water through the grounds in seconds. That meant it could extract rich flavor from the beans without turning bitter like old boiled coffee. The result was concentrated, aromatic, and had a creamy layer on top.

Cafés across Italy installed the machines. The style spread across Europe and eventually around the world. Most of the coffee drinks you know today—lattes, cappuccinos, flat whites, Americanos—they're variations on espresso, plus milk or water in different ratios.

But espresso was not the only coffee innovation to hit Europe at the turn of the twentieth century.

In 1908, Melitta Bentz, a housewife from Dresden, Germany, was frustrated with the coffee grounds that made it into her cup. So she took a page out of her son's school notebook and folded it into a cone. She put the coffee grounds on top of the paper, poured hot water over the grounds, and watched as a brewed beverage dripped out the bottom and into her cup.

That became what we call “filter coffee” or “drip coffee.” Unlike espresso, which forces hot water under pressure, filter coffee just uses gravity. Hot water passes over ground coffee beans, and drips into a cup or a pot. It brews more slowly. And the result is a less-concentrated beverage. An espresso shot is just one to two ounces. But a serving of drip coffee fills a cup or a mug.

This style became popular in Germany, Japan, Scandinavia, Canada, and the United States. This style is cheap and accessible. **Whether** you want to make just a single cup or fill a huge pot at a restaurant, the method is the same: hot water, grounds, filter, gravity.

But some people preferred that old style of coffee—and in Turkey, they still make it that way.

Turkish coffee is the closest we have today to the old, unfiltered style of coffee people made centuries ago. Cold water and sugar go into a small pot called a cezve, along with finely-ground coffee, almost powder-like. Boil it all together, pour into small cups, and sip carefully—leaving the sludge at the bottom.

If that's too strong and bitter for you, try Cuban coffee, a style that makes espresso sweet.

The secret is espumita. You start by putting sugar in a small cup. Add just the first few drops of coffee as it brews, then whip it vigorously until it turns pale and creamy. Pour the rest of the coffee over that foam. What you get is strong, sweet, and served in tiny cups—usually shared among friends. That is Cuban

coffee.

Sugar isn't the only way to make coffee sweet. In Vietnam, they use condensed milk instead. The method is closer to drip coffee than espresso. You put coffee grounds in a metal filter called a *phin*, which sits on top of your cup. Condensed milk goes in the cup first, then you pour hot water over the grounds. The coffee slowly drips into the condensed milk; it takes about four minutes. The result is a rich, creamy flavor that's both sweet and strong at the same time.

Jeff's take

I went to London as a student years ago and I tried to order what I thought was "normal" coffee. But they gave me an americano, which is just espresso mixed with hot water. That's not at all what I wanted. But that was the beginning of my coffee education: there is no "normal" style of coffee.

I recently tried Vietnamese coffee for the first time. It was just like I described it, sweet, creamy, and served cold. It was nothing like my typical morning cup, but I liked it.

My challenge to you: try a style you've never had. Not to judge which is better, but to understand that when people in Istanbul, Havana, Milan, and Ho Chi Minh City say "let's get coffee," they might all have something different in mind.

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